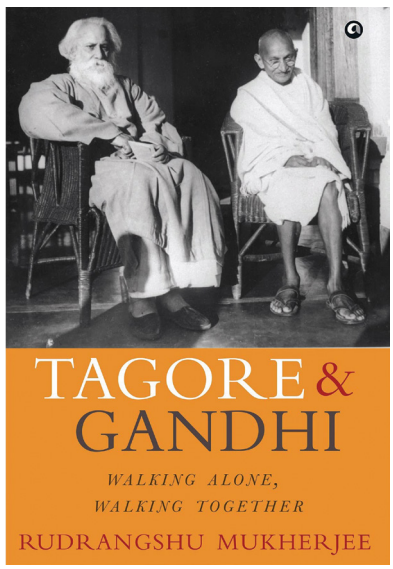
THE POET WRITES TO THE SAINT

By revisiting the correspondence of Gandhi and Tagore, historian **Rudrangshu Mukherjee** helps reveal aspects of their personalities we don't usually see



TAGORE & GANDHI
Walking Alone, Walking Together
by Rudrangshu Mukherjee
ALEPH
₹699; 208 pages

This book emerged from lectures in Ashoka University, whose vice-chancellor, till four years ago, was Rudrangshu Mukherjee. One of his students wrote: "Thank you, Prof. Mukherjee, for this wonderful session, mind-boggling one as if listening to Aesop's fables." He meant, of course, that it was as engaging, not that it was fiction. There would be no historiography if the past could be accurately reproduced; it is only because all that happens becomes irretrievable past instantly and can no longer be verified that the discipline of history emerges as recall. But there is a limit to the minds that can be applied to history, the eyes that read it, and the means of recording it. Hence there is more historical writing on those who distinguish themselves in some way or other. Amongst Indians, Rabindranath Tagore is the most distinguished litterateur and Gandhi the most distinguished politician in recent times. The connection between them is peripheral: each had his own background, training and mission. Mukherjee, who has returned to history after a distinguished journalistic career, delves into it.

Gandhi wrote, "The Poet is an inventor—he creates, destroys and recreates. I am an explorer and having discovered a thing I must cling to it." This was a polite description: actually, Gandhi is known as a passionate rebel against British colonial rule, though there was another side to him—a campaigner for narrow nationalism who wanted to protect India from the post-industrial ills of the West and turn it back into a rural economy—not quite the preindustrial one, for he also wanted to replace feudalism with cooperative egalitarianism. Tagore was a cosmopolitan who wanted to invite global cultures into India and create a new universal culture, of which his Visva-Bharati would be a pioneer. Both failed; India became a formal British-style democracy infected with autocratic Hindu nationalism, while Visva-Bharati became a largely conventional, none-too-great university. That is another story. This book covers the intellectual debate between them, carried out in personal meetings, correspondence as well as public writings.

Although they met only occasionally, Gandhi had tremendous respect for Tagore; he would often ask Tagore for his opinion on something that he was thinking of doing. Tagore would give him a frank response—on a satyagraha, for instance. They disagreed sometimes—for instance, on whether the 1934 Bihar earthquake was a product of divine will. They lived before the cellphone age, so their exchanges were recorded on paper—not necessarily by themselves, but also by intermediaries such as Charles Andrews and Mahadev Desai.

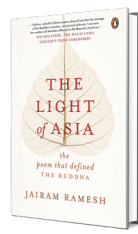
Thus, this book is a decades-long, complicated conversation; but more importantly, it is a record of the thought processes of Gandhi, who indefatigably made propaganda but did not generally disclose his inner reflections, and Tagore, who carried a heavy burden of artistic creation and institutional administration. It discloses a generally hidden side of both. Mukherjee found a niche, and he has illuminated it well. ■

–Ashok V. Desai

MY BEST OF 2021

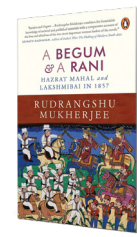


GOPALKRISHNA GANDHI
Former diplomat; Author of Refuge



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